

CHAROTAR UNIVERSITY OF SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY

Master of Business Administration (MBA)

Semester – I University Examination 2009-10

MB 702: Critical Thinking for Management

Date: 06 Jan. 2010, Wednesday

Time: 01.00 PM to 04.00 PM

Maximum Marks: 70

Instructions:

1. This paper contains six questions; the last one is a case analysis.
2. Answer all questions.
3. First five questions carry 10 marks each and the case analysis carries 20 marks.

Q1. (a) Determine whether the following passages are statements or not. If they are not statements, explain why they are not statements. [3x 1]

- (i) Human intelligence, imagination and intuition will continue in the foreseeable decades to be far more important than the machine.
- (ii) Industrialism broke society into thousands of interlocking parts-factories, churches, schools, trade unions, prisons, hospitals and the like.
- (iii) Do you want a readable guide to globalization?

(b) Determine whether the following passage is an argument or explanation and explain why it is so: [2]

True success always starts with an inner vision, however incomplete it might be. That's why most of the books on success by famous coaches, business stars, motivational consultants and psychologists begin with chapters on goal setting.

(c) In a certain mythical community, politicians never tell the truth and non-politicians always tell the truth. A stranger meets three natives and asks the first of them, "Are you a politician?" The first native answers the question. The second native then says, "The first native denied being a politician." The third native says that the first native is a politician. How many of these three natives are politicians?

Explain your answer.

[3]

(d) Determine whether the following arguments are deductive or inductive. State the reasons. [2x1]

- (i) If it rains, today's game will be postponed to next Saturday. According to the Indian Meteorological Department, there is a high probability of light showers today. Therefore, probably the game will be postponed to next Saturday.
- (ii) Every argument is either deductive or inductive. Because this argument is not deductive, it must be inductive.

Q2. (a) Identify the premises and conclusions in the following arguments [4x1]

- (i) Business is the art of growth. Growth is the essence of life. So our answer quickly follows - Business is the art of life.
- (ii) Science is based on experiment, on a willingness to change old dogma, on an openness to see the universe as it really is. Accordingly, science sometimes requires courage – at the very least the courage to question the conventional wisdom.
- (iii) There is nothing wrong with burning crude (oil) like crazy – oil isn't helping anyone when it sits in the ground – so long as there is a plan for energy alternatives when the cheap oil runs out.
- (iv) Frying is a drying process. It means that potatoes with high water content require more time and energy to cook than potatoes with a high solid content. The area of the slice with less moisture will fry faster than the area with more moisture. Therefore, the edges of the slice will fry faster than the middle and will curl.

(b) Diagram the following arguments: [2x3]

- (i) School tests should be abolished, as they introduce competition where it does not belong. They deny the individuality of students' talents and interests. They degrade education by encouraging passivity, mindlessness and triviality. Finally, they send wrong messages about what is valuable in education and in life.
- (ii) The rule of equal incomes is socially impracticable. It would deter the great majority of the more efficient from putting forth their best efforts and turning out their maximum product. As a consequence, the total volume of product would be so diminished as to render the share of the great majority of persons smaller than it would have been under a rational plan of unequal distribution.

Q3. (a) Identify the fallacies, if there are any, in the following passages and discuss them. If no fallacy has been committed, write 'no fallacy'. [5x2]

- (i) At the global warming conference in Kyoto, many developing nations argued against setting strict emission standards, claiming that this would put them at a competitive disadvantage against rich industrialised nations that have already benefited from lax environmental standards. But these developing nations are just jealous of the high standard of living that industrialised nations have achieved. Sour grapes, that's all their arguments amount to.
- (ii) Everything that exists is animal, vegetable, or mineral. The number '7' obviously isn't an animal or a vegetable. Therefore, the number '7' is a mineral.
- (iii) There is nothing wrong in segregating restrooms on the basis of the class of travel. After all, we have always had separate restrooms for men and women and nobody seems to complain about that.
- (iv) Kant said that whenever anything would go wrong at his last job, his boss would always say he was responsible. I guess Kant must be a very responsible person. I'd better hire him.
- (v) I don't believe in superstitions. They're bad luck.

Q4. (a) Translate the following into standard categorical form and test the validity of the argument using Venn diagrams: [5]

There are e-mail messages that are not spell-checked. There are inter-office memos that are e-mail messages. Therefore, there are interoffice memos that are not spell-checked.

(b) Put the following argument in symbolic form and test its validity using a truth table: [5]

Students can raise their grades by studying hard, but not by doing extra-credit courses. It is not the case that students can raise their grades by doing extra-credit courses and having additional inputs from a faculty member. So, students can raise their grades by studying hard and having additional inputs from a faculty member.

Q5. The sentences numbered 1 to 7 are not presented in their logical sequence. Rearrange the sentences and present them as a well-written passage that can be comprehended by the reader without difficulty. Include the sentence numbers in your answer. [10]

1. 'Customer relationship marketing' means that a customer's purchasing record can be tracked so that a message can be sent to a customer noting that they bought, say, one book by a particular author and so, requesting whether they would like to buy the new one.
2. In return, visitors often provide information about themselves (name, address, demographic profile).
3. The internet is opening up many new marketing opportunities.
4. E-mail, like the telephone, works best on a one-to-one basis.
5. Thousands of corporations have developed websites on the internet where 'visitors' can register to get more information.
6. This avoids accusations of unsolicited bulk e-mailings.
7. Improved software means that corporations can directly write to the person ('Dear Anand') on an individual basis, rather than on a general one ('Dear customer').

Q6. The following passage is reproduced (with some changes) from an article titled 'Media's Decade' by Sunil Jain, which appeared in Business Standard, January 04, 2010. Present a critical essay on the article. [20]

Sunil Jain: Media's decade

The government is seen as the oppressor and the media the saviour.

Sunil Jain / New Delhi January 04, 2010, 0:20 IST

One of the more exciting industries of the decade has surely been the media one. Not just from the point of view of growth — with newspaper/magazine sales rising from Rs 7,000 crore in 2000 to Rs 19,500 crore in 2008, its growth has been better than the power sector, oil and gas, textiles and FMCG, though worse than refineries, steel and the automobile sector. And, unlike mature western democracies, readership levels are rising here.

What made it the media's decade, of course, goes beyond the growth in top line sales to the view that the only body which can move a thoroughly rotten system is the media. Whether it was the Tehelka tapes of 2001 or the gunning down of Jessica Lal or the Nitish Katara murder, a relentless media ensured that the government did things the right way. In the Jessica Lal case, the killers who were let off due to lack of evidence, were brought to trial once again. And if, after 19 years, former Haryana Director General of Police SPS Rathore is finally sentenced for molesting Ruchika Girotra and filing all manner of police cases against her brother and then torturing him (all of which drove her to suicide), it will only be due to media pressure — that the entire political and bureaucratic class in Haryana covered up all this time tells you just how deep the rot is. The list goes on.

In terms of exposing corruption, once again, it has been media campaigns that made the difference. While the highest in the government kept quiet as telecom minister A Raja was gifting away Rs 50,000 crore to a select few firms, it was the media that highlighted and pursued the scandal. The vigilance commission came into the picture later. When the Delhi airport's owners were trying to diddle the government of its share of revenue, it was the media pressure that forced the government to act to reduce this somewhat. Ditto for the allegations on Reliance Industries Limited (RIL) padding its KG Basin costs. After incorrectly stating that the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) had found nothing wrong, the head of the Directorate General of Hydrocarbons (DGH) had to backtrack and ask CAG to audit the accounts. Later, the DGH head had to leave after the media said he'd accepted a flat from RIL — while the government is probing the charge, he was refused the extension which was a certainty till then. This list, too, goes on.

The media, of course, has traditionally been seen as a check when the executive, the judiciary and the legislature have failed to deliver, but what has changed is that the traditional protectors have become more effete. Parliament functions less and less with each passing day. While the Lok Sabha sat for 151 days in 1956, this fell to 64 days in 2009; Budget discussions lasted for 140 hours in 1986 and this fell to 60 hours in 2006 and 2007 and then rose to 95 hours in 2009; 27 per cent of Bills were passed in just five minutes last year and, on an average, just nine MPs participated per Bill passed. As for the judiciary, just between June and September last year, the number of pending cases in the Supreme Court rose from 52,592 to 53,221 and the total number of pending cases in various high courts is 40,18,914! As for the executive, cases like Ruchika and Raja make it clear just what it is capable of. Also, believe it or not, the size of government in areas that matter is small compared to other countries and, in terms of share of GDP, this has fallen from 12.9 per cent in 1999-2000 to 11.1 per cent in 2008-09. This explains the inability to deliver, whether it is water, electricity or even justice. Naturally then, people in distress turn to the media.

The problem here is that, while the media may do a great job, this is almost always subjective and, more often than not, guided by the People Like Us syndrome — how often were the victims at the Chhatrapati Shivaji Terminal recalled in the Mumbai terrorist attack in comparison to those at the Taj and the Oberoi? On other occasions, as in the Aarushi Talwar murder case, the media convicted her parents, forcing the CBI to arrest her father for several weeks.

No civilised society and certainly not one hoping to become a great power over the next few decades can hope to work with sporadic justice. The media's justice may have, to use a recent example, got aged historian Lotika Sarkar her house back after a policeman and his wife said she had gifted it to them, but it was the Lucknow High Court verdict in the Anil Ambani Dadri power project case a few weeks ago that determined lakhs of farmers across the country cannot just be evicted from their property by a government using emergency powers which prevent them from even voicing their dissent. That is, the fourth estate cannot possibly equal the power of the other estates when they function well. This was the media's decade, but for all the wrong reasons.